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STUDENT HANDOUT

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Why People Move: The Great Migration

Grades 5–8 · Social Studies

The Mini Museum

ADMIT ONE

NAME	DATE	CLASS

Challenge context: The Harlem Renaissance was not merely an artistic movement — it was a political strategy, a cultural assertion, and a community-building project. Understanding it requires grappling with questions of power, identity, authenticity, and what art is ultimately for.

01

ACTIVITY 1 · TWO WAVES — ONE MOVEMENT?

The Great Migration Was Not One Event

Historians distinguish between the First Great Migration (1910–1940) and the Second Great Migration (1940–1970). Research both and complete the comparison:

	FIRST MIGRATION (1910–1940)	SECOND MIGRATION (1940–1970)
Scale		
Primary destinations		
Key push factors		
Key pull factors		
Cultural impact		

The Second Migration occurred after the Harlem Renaissance had already demonstrated Black cultural achievement.

Why did Black Americans still feel the need to leave the South in even larger numbers after 1940?

02

ACTIVITY 2 · WHAT DID "SUCCESS" LOOK LIKE?

Evaluating the Movement

The Great Migration is sometimes described as a success — migrants found better wages, more freedom, and the opportunity for cultural flourishing. It is also described as a partial failure — Northern racism persisted, housing discrimination was widespread, and many migrants found themselves trapped in poor urban neighborhoods.

Write a structured argument: on balance, was the Great Migration successful for the people who made it?

03

ACTIVITY 3 · THE GEOGRAPHY OF POWER

Why Did the Renaissance Happen in Harlem Specifically?

By 1930, Harlem had become the largest Black urban community in America — 175,000 people in a few square miles. Analyze the geographic, economic, and social factors that made Harlem — rather than Chicago's South Side, or Detroit's Paradise Valley — the epicenter of the Renaissance:

Critical question: Jacob Lawrence's *Migration Series* (1941) depicted the Great Migration in 60 paintings. He donated half to the Museum of Modern Art and half to the Phillips Collection — splitting a single work between two institutions. What does this act tell us about how he understood the relationship between Black experience and mainstream American culture?

Research extension: The Reverse Migration began in the 1970s and continues today — Black Americans moving back to the South. Research this movement. What does it tell us about how the push/pull dynamics of the original Great Migration have changed? What does it mean for cities like Atlanta, Charlotte, and Houston?

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: If the Harlem Renaissance exhibition is available at your school, visit the Mini Museum to experience the phonograph, Jazz Lab, Great Migration Map, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a class visit.

Option 2 — Virtual visit: minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance